

rent course material online. But just because it's online doesn't mean it's any less serious. You will have to go through a list of reading lists, assignments, etc. Let's take a look at some pointers before we begin looking for free online education.

► **Commitment**

As a society we're very used to a typical classroom type of a situation, where the lecturer is teaching and you're either taking down notes or just plain fooling around. You're confined to classrooms and have dedicated timings. With online learning, while the teacher is present, the timings are upto you. You can take the courses whenever you like, at your convenience. Now add zero cost to consuming these lectures, and there's a very high possibility that you may just randomly enroll for courses without really attending them. Beware!

It's very easy to get side-tracked while doing free online courses, as there's no monitoring mechanism. It's all upto you. You have to set aside time for the course. You have to persevere and study as if you were doing a local college course. You have to be committed for it to be successful.

► **Aim for knowledge, not for a degree**

One of the first questions that many people have about free online courses is, "Will I get a certificate after I finish the course?" The obsession for certificates has to stop if you want to gain knowledge. Sure, there are some online courses that offer course-completion certificates. But that shouldn't be your aim. Take these free online courses as an opportunity to get to know about fields which you'd never know about otherwise. For a student studying engineering, it's almost impossible to take up a course in the humanities in the Indian educational scenario, but in the online world, you have a range of disciplines at your disposal. You can gain immense knowledge from these courses provided with the right focus. Degrees and certificates, you're anyway getting from your real-world courses. Not getting one for the online course you did won't hurt. Your choice of course is purely to improve your knowledge on a subject, not to prove a point to anyone.

► **Explore the course offline as well**

Just attending an online lecture is not sufficient. Just like your regular college course, if you really want to get the most out of the free online course, you should invest in tools to improve your knowledge. Since the course is free,